are lucky that we have such a passionate fanbase for the sport in the country.

Looking back at the four months between January and April 1998, I feel a sense of deep satisfaction. I had led the charge against the Australians and had enjoyed the personal contest against Shane Warne. But it didn't stop there. I went on to bat at close to my best throughout 1998 and in November played my part in winning us the Champions Trophy tri-series at Sharjah against Sri Lanka and Zimbabwe.

What I remember about that competition is that the Zimbabwe fast bowler Henry Olonga had taken me by surprise in the last match of the group stage with a short ball and the manner of my dismissal had kept me restless right up to the final. So much so that I decided I had to settle the scores. It was like in boxing – either you go down or I go down. In the final I managed to score 124 off ninety-two balls, but I must confess that some of my shots were not what you might call orthodox cricketing shots, as all I was doing was smashing the ball. That's what happens when you are batting well – even slogs go for boundaries – whereas during a lean patch, you get out to bad balls.

## Invitations I couldn't turn down

A few months before that Champions Trophy, in July and August 1998, two things happened that I will never forget. The first was that I was invited to play in the Princess Diana Memorial Match at Lord's on 18 July. The opposition bowling line-up included Glenn McGrath, Javagal Srinath, Allan Donald and Anil Kumble, and I managed to score 125 against them while opening the batting. Though I didn't manage to make a hundred at Lord's in Test cricket, this was a ton I have fond memories of, especially because it came against a top-quality bowling attack.

The second memorable thing happened in August when Shane Warne and I had the great honour of being invited to visit Sir Don Bradman at his house in Adelaide on the occasion of his ninetieth birthday. We were both very nervous about meeting the great man and I remember debating with Shane in the taxi on the way about who should talk to him first. I said that it should be Shane, because he's a fellow Australian; he said that it should be me, because I'm a fellow batsman. In the end, Sir Don, who fondly referred to me as 'Bonzer', took control of proceedings as soon as we arrived and quickly made us feel at ease.